Johann Heinrich Jung-Stilling — Scenen aus dem Geisterreiche (1795–1801)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

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Dedication

To Johann Heinrich Jung-Stilling, the tailor's son from a Westphalian village who taught school as a boy, learned the treatment of the eye, and became celebrated for restoring sight in cases of cataract. The same man wrote, in dialogue, scenes of the world no eye can see. He never left the Pietist faith of his early surroundings, even as friendship with Goethe carried his first book into print. This presentation is dedicated to the physician who gave sight to others, and to the scenes English readers have never been given whole.

The story

Johann Heinrich Jung was born on 12 September 1740 at Grund, near Hilchenbach in Westphalia. His father, Wilhelm Jung, was a schoolmaster and tailor, and his grandfather Eberhard Jung was a charcoal burner. His early years were spent in poverty, and at his father's wish he became a schoolmaster and tailor himself, teaching from his teens. A Roman Catholic clergyman of the neighbourhood taught him a treatment for diseases of the eye, a gift he profited from for the rest of his life.

In 1768 he went to study medicine at the University of Strasbourg. There he

met Goethe, who introduced him to Herder, and the acquaintance ripened into friendship. By Goethe's influence, Jung's first work, *Heinrich Stillings Jugend*, was published, without Jung's knowledge, in 1777. The book concealed his surname and gave him the invented name Stilling, which may derive from the description of German Pietists as the still people in the countryside. His autobiography, *Heinrich Stillings Leben*, remains the principal source for his life, and the *Jugend* is considered an important precursor of the Bildungsroman.

In 1772 he settled at Elberfeld as physician and oculist, and soon became celebrated for cataract operations, performing over 3,000 of them in his lifetime. In 1778 he accepted a lectureship at the newly established school at Kaiserslautern, a post he held when the school was absorbed into the University of Heidelberg in 1784. In 1787 he became professor of economic, financial, and statistical studies at Marburg. He resigned in 1803, returned to Heidelberg, and in 1806 received a pension from Charles Frederick, Grand Duke of Baden, and moved to Karlsruhe. He was married three times and fathered thirteen children. He died at Karlsruhe on 2 April 1817.

Through all of this his first interest lay in serving the kingdom of God. His later writings turned to prophecy, the future life, and the spirit world, and among them the *Scenen aus dem Geisterreiche* holds a distinct place.

The work and what survives

The *Scenen aus dem Geisterreiche*, in English "Scenes from the Spirit Realm," is a work of dialogued afterlife scenes, published across 1795–1801. Reference works list it as a distinct work from the *Theorie der Geisterkunde* of 1808, and one older account counts its scenes among the most interesting of his mystical writings, describing the scenes it presented as often well nigh majestic.

The German text survives. The 1795 Frankfurt edition (Varrentrapp und Wenner), held in the Harold Jantz Collection at Duke, is listed with page images at HathiTrust by the Online Books Page. Later editions run to a fifth edition. The work is in the public domain: the author died in 1817.

Its English fortunes

Other books by Jung-Stilling did reach English. Samuel Jackson translated the

autobiography *Leben* in 1835 and the *Theorie der Geisterkunde* at London in 1834, with a New York printing in 1851, and the Reverend Samuel Schaeffer translated *Theobald, or the Fanatic* in 1846. The reference listings that flag those English editions flag none for the *Scenen*.

No English translation found after research — searches returned German editions, HathiTrust records, and incidental modern mentions only.

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean translating the dialogued scenes entire, from the German. The first task would be edition collation, setting the 1795 first part against the expanded 1795–1801 sequence and the fifth edition, so the translation rests on a settled text. A HathiTrust access check would also be needed, since some Jantz page images are accessible only in the United States.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Johann_Heinrich_Jung (life, Goethe, career, autobiography, English translations, work list)
- https://www.studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/bri/j/johann-heinrich-jung.html (1911 Britannica entry: life and English translations)
- https://gameo.org/index.php?title=Jung-Stilling,*Johann_Heinrich*(1740-1817) (Pietist, physician and economist; career summary)
- https://www.studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/mse/s/stilling-jung.html (eye treatment, mystical stories and the *Scenen*)
- https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Page:The_New_International_Encyclop%C3%A6dia_1st_ed._v._11.djvu/361 (distinct-work listing; no English flag for the *Scenen*)
- https://onlinebooks.library.upenn.edu/webbin/book/lookupid?key=ha100110486 (*Scenen* entry; page images at HathiTrust)